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In a country that celebrates showmanship, Jasprit Bumrah has built his legend on restraint.

He is nothing like the fast bowlers from folklore. His art is not violent. There are no loose strands of long hair falling across and sticking to his sweaty face, and there is no chest-thumping. Instead, he resembles a craftsman of unwonted calm, almost like a quiet mechanic of collapse.

There is no elaborate ceremony to his run-up. Cricket Australia's official website perhaps best describes his routine: "A lackadaisical approach to the wicket, sometimes off no more than six paces..."

And then, as if manufactured from thin air, comes the crack of a whip off that storied hyperextended right arm. Bumrah would have made many a batter, not exactly men of science, turn to AI to enquire about the Magnus Effect, the phenomenon that causes the ball to experience an upward drift from the point of release due to heavy backspin. His rubbery snap-back release action garnishes the deliveries with an additional splattering of venom.

The 2026 T20 World Cup never strayed from the script. Just when a partnership grew teeth, when the scoreboard began rolling, and when the fielders were sent chasing leather through widening outfielders, skipper Suryakumar Yadav knew he had the option to 'phone a friend'. He understood he could bend the outcome in his favour by eliminating 24 balls out of the equation. Ahmedabad's homeboy never disappointed.

Bumrah finished the tournament with 14 wickets, tied for the most alongside Varun Chakaravathy. His 4/15 in the final is a career best. Among players to have bowled 100-plus deliveries, Bumrah now has the best economy rate for three editions in a row: 5.08 in 2021, 4.17 in 2024, and 6.21 in 2026. He also has

the best bowling average among pacers who have bowled in excess of 100 balls: 12.42.

These numbers are perhaps what will define India's cricketing history. At the same time, they will never quite capture the true essence of Bumrah's career. They cannot record the collective sigh of relief of an entire stadium simply because he has the ball in hand.

"He is a once-in-a-generation bowler; I can call him a national treasure right now. He knows what needs to be done and how it needs to be done," the skipper said of his safety net after beating New Zealand by 96 runs in the final.

"He is the best in the business, and hopefully he keeps doing what he is doing."

Even if one strips away the recency bias — the memory of Bumrah's metronomic cutters shredding New Zealand's plans in the summit clash — examples of the 32-year-old turning matches on their head are far too many.

If one were to hop onto a time machine and land at the Nassau County Stadium in the early hours of June 9, 2024, they would catch India defending a paltry 119 in the T20 WC against Pakistan. All thanks to Bumrah's disciplined bowling that triggered a collapse, starting with the dismissal of a well-set Mohammad Rizwan. The batter, dictating terms until moments earlier, suddenly found the ground shifting beneath his feet.

"Tried to hit the seam as much as I could. Tried to be as clear as I could with my execution, and it all came out well, so I feel happy. You stick to

your processes and look to play well," Bumrah, named Player of the Match for figures of 3/14, said.

And so he did. He stuck to his processes and came out with flying colours in the final against South Africa as well. It was in the 16th over that captain Rohit Sharma handed him the ball. He was supposed to undo the damage Heinrich Klaasen had caused in Axar Patel's previous over. Twenty-four runs were scored, and South Africa needed to go at a mere run a ball in the next five overs to bring the trophy home. But Bumrah had other plans. He conceded only six and picked up a wicket off his final two overs. At the death of an innings, when most bowlers are trying to survive, Bumrah hunts.

Then there was that one time in 2020 when the Kiwis needed 24 off the last two overs. Runs were coming thick and fast at Mount Maunganui that day. Bumrah responded by delivering an inch-perfect yorker in the penultimate over to send Tim Southee home and conceding only three runs. The writing was on the wall.

One would perhaps need to write an entire manuscript to chronicle the many occasions when Bumrah has dragged India back from the jaws of defeat.

"It's like having a genie; you just rub the lamp, and out comes Bumrah," Faf du Plessis recently told *ESPNcricinfo*. Genie or genius, it scarcely matters. What does matter is that every time a match threatens to unravel, India's quietest warrior, for whom crisis has become a habitat, is the first to step up.



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